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Purported, Alleged, Undetermined

Four Degrees of Doubt in the Ogham Corpus

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1 · Doubt is written down, then lost

Epigraphic editions mark their doubt with care: what is unclear, restored or lost, and where editors disagree. When an edition becomes a knowledge graph, that care often vanishes, and a hesitant reading looks exactly like a confident one.

The idea: one pipeline, two axes

Two open Python pipelines read the same TEI/EpiDoc editions of the OG(H)AM project.

- **Axis 1, structure:** a class-based crosswalk into CIDOC CRM and CRMtex.
- **Axis 2, doubt:** every competing reading becomes a weighted statement in the Academic Meta Tool (AMT).
- Each reading names its editor, so a weight can be traced to its source.

Four degrees of doubt: one ladder of Ogham stones

garranes-ciic81.jpg

Garranes (CIIC 81). 3 supplied letters; the editor writes the reading is not really in doubt.

dyke.jpg

Dyke. 12 unclear, 9 gaps, 3 pairs of alternative letters; edition and date marked low certainty.

blackwaterfoot-1.jpg

Blackwaterfoot 1. 9 apparatus notes, 6 competing readings; date marked low precision.

bishop-loch.jpg

Bishop Loch. 2 gaps, no uncertainty markup: the doubt is in the prose.

How the doubt travels: from the stone's edition to a weighted graph

1. **Mark up** — TEI/EpiDoc: unclear, supplied, gap, choice, app, cert
2. **Crosswalk** — Linked Ogham ontology to CIDOC CRM and CRMtex
3. **Weigh** — each reading a reified statement with amt:weight
4. **Reason** — AMT engine over weighted statements; axioms still to write

1 · How TEI says 'not sure'

The editors of OG(H)AM already encode doubt. We read the signals and give each a certainty between 0 and 1.

EpiDoc	Means	Certainty
`<unclear>`	not clearly legible	0.5
`<supplied>`	restored by the editor	0.3
`<gap>`	lost, not restored	0.0
`<choice>`	two letters possible	to do
`cert`, `precision`	the editor hedges	to do
`<app>`, `<rdg>`	another editor read otherwise	agreement

2 · Into CIDOC CRM

Linked Ogham classes sit between the edition and CIDOC CRM, so the ontology is the crosswalk. Coordinates keep their hedge: 475 asserted, 6 qualified, 3 given as text only, 20 missing.

EpiDoc	CIDOC CRM / CRMtex
`<support>`	E22 Human-Made Object
edition `<div>`	TX1 Written Text
a reading	TX7 segment, attributed to its editor (PROV-O)
`<origPlace>`, `<geo>`	E53 Place with a coordinate status
`<persName>`	E21 Person

3 · Weighing readings

A weight combines how legible a reading is (c) with how many editors agree with it (a), shared out over the alternatives: `weight = c · a / Σ c · a`. The weights of a stone add up to 1.

Reading	Editor	Weight
VICULA MAQ COMGINI	Macalister 1902	0.2727
VICULA MAQ CUGINI	Macalister 1945	0.2727
[---]MAQ[---]COGIN[---]	OG(H)AM edition	0.1818
MAQICAGILEB	Rhys 1899	0.1818
OGMA MAQI TIGERNI	Rhys 1901	0.0909

Where the method does not see the doubt

- **One reading always weighs 1.0.** Garranes has three restored letters, yet scores 1.0: the damage shows in the type of doubt, not in the number.
- **Doubt in prose is invisible.** Bishop Loch has two gaps and no uncertainty markup, so it also scores 1.0. Whether its marks are ogham at all is said only in words such as *purported*.
- **Next:** read `<choice>` and `cert`; model the status of an object as a kind of doubt.

Material fact, or editorial history?

34 records marked doubtful

21 of them British

The corpus marks 34 records as doubtful, 21 of them British. Do they reflect a material fact, or the history of who looked at them and how?

Explore

Axis 1 Crosswalk

Axis 2 AMT

AMT.engine

OG(H)AM editions

People



Florian Thiery

Behind the work

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